

Surface Pro teared-down

"iFixit", the website popular for tearing apart devices has teared down the Microsoft Surface Pro tablet
<http://dgit.in/VTROCs>

**LHC stops for 2 years**

The particle accelerator which is in search of the "God Particle" has been shut down for the next two years to undergo repairs

Careers in Web Designing

Be an architect of the web and in turn shape your own future. Read on to find out how...

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What are the first thoughts that come to your mind when you hear "web designing"? Obviously, it would involve the web and creativity. And you're not wrong, the basic premise is pretty straightforward: There's a medium (the internet), a delivery method (a browser) and an end-user, and the job of the web designer is to create content, deliver it and run usability and readability checks to ensure that everything runs the way it is intended to.

Starting with the basics

There are prerequisites to becoming a web designer. Since this is a knowledge intensive job you need to have sound knowledge of mark-up languages such as HTML, XHTML and XML; stylesheet languages such as CSS and XSL; client-side scripting such as Javascript; server-side scripting PHP and ASP; database technologies such as MySQL and PostgreSQL; graphics design tools like Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator and Adobe InDesign; and Multimedia technologies like Flash and Silverlight. If these terms sound overwhelming, you probably haven't taken your first steps into the coding world just yet. Don't worry, start small with the basics like HTML. Later you can specialise in one or more amongst these based on what interests you, although it does help to have broad-based knowledge – it's what separates an average designer from the pros. Tenacity and an eye for detail are also key to success.

You may wonder "How is web designing different from programming and graphics designing?" Graphics design

is a much wider field and is not limited to the web. When applied solely to the web, graphics designing is the part that forms the visual aspects of the site; whereas web programming involves writing the code that lends the website the functionality that makes the design work. A web designer has knowledge of both programming and graphics designing. The job profile also depends on the size and structure of the company that you work in. In smaller companies, everyone does a little bit of everything – the work is shared and overlaps amongst people.

A Web designer's day

A typical day starts with the designer sitting down with clients for a thorough need-analysis. This is where communication and assimilation skills come in handy; after all a job well understood is a job half done. In most cases, the client will provide you with required inputs such as text, imagery, logo, fonts and pictures; there are exceptions where the designer is asked to create these aspects too.

G. Sai Nihlas, who works as a freelancer for 3SixtyFive, a social media and branding firm, sums up his typical day like this: "on an average I work for about 7-8 hours, and I use Adobe Photoshop CS5, Adobe Illustrator CS5 and Adobe InDesign CS5. Also, I think what separates an average designer from a master is the amount of creativity involved and the time taken to accomplish the project." Nihlas further clarifies that his work mainly involves creating the interface i.e. the overall look of the page, hence he doesn't need to fiddle with the functionality part of the website which involves programming. There's an important distinction to be made here between web designers and web developers. Binny V.A., a freelance web developer, gives us his per-

spective: "People outside the web development field, say desktop programmers and managers, usually club us web designers and web developers together. But no one in the web development field will confuse the two. That being said, there are quite a few programmers who are great at designing and development and vice-versa."

Once the designer has the concept and the content, he converts these into a design that is both, intriguing and user-friendly.

A smart designer will, over and above the basic skills and knowledge, use the many smart-tools available to enhance his productivity. This may include, but is not limited to website downtime diagnostic tools, automated form designing services, progress monitor software, organization tools, online collaboration tools and website traffic analysis tools. Apart from these, Binny V.A. preaches the importance of an online presence as an edge in order to connect within the industry and source work: "Many clients have contacted me after seeing my blog. So, I would classify my blogging and social network activities as part of my job as well. That makes Twitter one of the tools of the trade."

Being good on paper helps, but don't let the lack of it stop you

Since the nature of work is not managerial and merit is assessed on the basis of level of skills, the academic requirements in the field are not rigid or set in stone. That being said, large corporations, in most cases won't even consider you if you don't have at least a bachelor's degree in Computer Sciences or Engineering. But if you've proven your mettle, have an impressive portfolio and possess a sound knowledge of computer science, programming, advertising, graphics, and art and design you should have no trouble picking up freelance jobs and full-time positions in start-ups and smaller organizations.

To this effect Nihlas opines, "of course, certifications and educational credentials do help, you basically get to charge at least 25% more if you have a qualification, because it helps the client have more confidence in you and as a result of that, he wouldn't mind shelling out some extra cash."